



KAYLA BARTKOWSKI Los Angeles Times

DESPITE a new state law, the Kendall family of Pacific Palisades was denied 12 months of mortgage relief.

15 killed in attack at Jewish event in Sydney

Shooters at Hanukkah celebration on Bondi Beach are father and son, authorities say.

BY KRISTEN GELINEAU, CHARLOTTE GRAHAM-McLAY AND ROD MCGUIRK

SYDNEY — Two gunmen opened fire during a Hanukkah celebration on Sydney's Bondi Beach, killing 15 people, including a child, officials said Monday, in what Prime Minister Anthony Albanese called an act of antisemitic terrorism that struck at the heart of the nation. The shooters were father and son, authorities said.

The massacre at one of Australia's most popular beaches — in an area with a large Jewish community — followed a wave of antisemitic attacks that have roiled the country over the last year, although the authorities didn't suggest those episodes and Sunday's shooting were connected. It is the deadliest shooting in almost three decades in a country with strict gun control laws.

One gunman, 50, was fatally shot by police. The other shooter, his 24-year-old son, was wounded and being treated at a hospital, said Mal Lanyon, the New South Wales police commissioner.

Police said one gunman was known to security services, but Lanyon said authorities had no indication of a planned attack.

Those killed were between 10 and 87 years old, New South Wales Premier Chris Minns told reporters. At least 38 others were injured in the attack.

[See **Bondi Beach**, A4]

On darkest days, 'we light candles'

Jewish leaders urge Angelenos to shine brighter than ever at celebrations in wake of the tragedy. **A4**

U.S. indictment alleges child sex abuse ring

BY CLARA HARTER AND BRITNY MEJIA

This article contains descriptions of sexual violence.

The 15-year-old girl was sitting in her bedroom when "Sociopath" and "Rohan" added her to a Discord chat that, several months later, would nearly end in her death.

She said within hours of joining the chat on the online messaging platform in 2020, she became the target

of a network of predators who, according to federal prosecutors in an indictment, specialize in coercing minors to perform sex acts and self-harm on camera.

She said she initially met Sociopath, identified in the indictment as Kaleb Merritt, during the pandemic on Discord servers dedicated to online games. She said he offered her an upgraded version of Discord in exchange for a conversation. Then, he added her to the chat with Rohan — later identified in the indictment as Rohan Rane.

The teen, whose name is being withheld because of safety concerns, had no idea she was being pulled into a highly organized and terrifying scheme that has ensnared minors across America, including girls in Los Angeles and San Bernardino, according to interviews with victims and federal agents, and a federal indictment in the Central District Court of California.

Members of the sex-ploitation ring seek vulnerable girls, having found many in online communities dedi-

[See **Sex abuse**, A6]



FEDERICO PARRA AFP/Getty Images

SOCIAL MEDIA have fueled talk of a U.S. invasion and the fate of Venezuelan President Nicolás Maduro. Above, his supporters rally Saturday.

Venezuela's holidays shadowed by rumors

BY MERY MOGOLLÓN AND PATRICK J. McDONNELL

CARACAS, Venezuela — Even in Venezuela, a nation battered by years of economic, social and political turmoil, the Christmas season is a time to put aside one's troubles, spend time with family, enjoy a bit of holiday cheer — if you can escape the ubiquitous uncertainty and rumors that mark life here.

On one day social media will be ablaze with reports that President Nicolás Maduro has fled to Brazil. Or to Turkey. Or that he stopped in Turkey on his way to Qatar. Or that the U.S. invasion had begun. None of it (so far) is true.

Social media fuel the daily rumor mill, in part because access to independent news is severely restricted.

"One hears so much on social media but learns little," said Begoña Monasterio, 78, who was out shopping in Caracas, the capital, for ingredients to prepare las hallacas, the country's emblematic Christmas dish. It's a succulent mix of cornmeal, meat, olives, raisins and other delectables cooked and wrapped in banana leaves, a kind of Venezuelan tamale.

"I want to give a surprise to my eldest son, who is having a birthday during the holiday," said the grandmother.

She toted a small shopping bag and vowed to buy "the minimum," now the custom in a once-wealthy South America.

[See **Venezuela**, A3]

Mortgage law doesn't help all fire victims

Servicers sometimes deny relief, despite state officials' promises

BY LAURENCE DARMIENTO

After business consultant Len Kendall lost his Pacific Palisades home in the January firestorms, he sought to put a temporary stop on his mortgage payments but set aside the effort after realizing the paperwork involved.

So he was pleased to learn in September about a new state law that required mortgage servicers to offer up to 12 months of relief to fire victims, with only an affirmation of financial hardship and a ban on lump sum repayments.

However, Kendall was shocked when his servicer told him he didn't qualify, which prompted him to fight back. He was finally offered three months of relief in October, the minimum initial amount required under the law.

But what also surprised him was being told he would have to repay what he owed in a lump sum — though he could be "evaluated" for other repayment options, according to messages reviewed by The Times.

"If they were to offer a forbearance to people, it really wouldn't cost them much. It would just be a delay in getting the same amount of money, and even that they're unwilling to do in this ex-

treme situation," said Kendall, 42, who lived in the home with his wife and toddler. "It's just ghoulish."

Kendall is among dozens of homeowners who were victims of the Palisades and Eaton fires who allege that their banks and mortgage services aren't giving them the relief they expected from a state law that was intended to help them.

Among the complaints are denials that fail to cite legal justification, demands for lump sum repayments and servicers reporting borrowers to credit bureaus.

The law through which Kendall sought assistance, Assembly Bill 238, was signed by Gov. Gavin Newsom in September. It strengthened a voluntary program he had created in January that 420 institutions signed on to and which initially provided just three months of relief.

It's unclear how many homeowners have applied for mortgage forbearance under the law, which applies to victims of the Eaton and Palisades fires and the concurrent windstorms.

But Assemblymember John Harabedian (D-Pasadena), who co-sponsored the legislation, said his office has received about two dozen complaints accusing lenders and servicers of not complying with the law.

[See **Mortgage**, A12]

Shift on hep B shot guide seen as risky

BY SONJA SHARP

For most American infants, the hepatitis B shot comes just before their first bath, in the blur of pokes, prods and pictures that attend a 21st century hospital delivery.

But as of last week, thousands of newborns across the U.S. will no longer receive the initial inoculation for hepatitis B — the first in a litany of childhood vaccinations and the top defense against one of the world's deadliest cancers.

On Dec. 5, the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention's powerful vaccine advisory panel voted to nix the decades-old birth-dose recommendation.

The change was pushed by Health and Human Services Secretary Robert F.

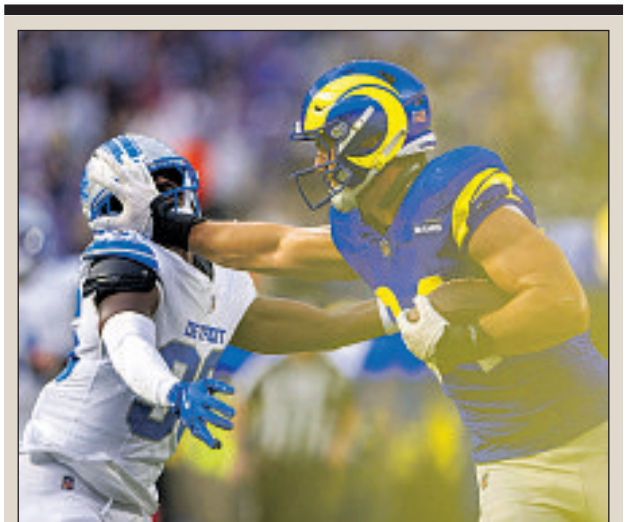
Kennedy Jr. and his "Make America Healthy Again" movement, which has long sought to rewrite the CDC's childhood vaccine schedule and unwind state immunization requirements for kindergarten.

California officials have vowed to keep the state's current guidelines in place, but the federal changes could threaten vaccine coverage by some insurers and public benefits programs, along with broader reverberations.

"It's a gateway," said Jessica Malaty Rivera, an infectious-disease epidemiologist in Los Angeles. "It's not just hepatitis B — it's chipping away at the entire schedule."

Democratic-led states and blue-chip insurance companies have scrambled

[See **Vaccine**, A8]



ERIC THAYER Los Angeles Times

PUSH TO PLAYOFFS

Colby Parkinson and the Rams fend off the Lions 41-34 to secure postseason berth. **SPORTS, D1**

Arrest made in Brown shooting

Eight students remain in critical condition after the attack on the Rhode Island campus that killed 2. **NATION, A5**

Weather
Sunny and warmer.
L.A. Basin: 79/52. **B5**

'Extraordinary' aquatic sighting

Researchers spot a rare, giant seven-arm octopus in Monterey Bay. **CALIFORNIA, B1**



Improved L.A. traffic isn't all good news

BY TERRY CASTLEMAN

Los Angeles has experienced more than its share of struggles in the last few years.

But when it comes to one of the things that drive residents crazy, there are signs of slight improvement.

New data show that the home of Carmageddon, the SigAlert and road rage has

actually seen traffic congestion get a bit better.

Los Angeles was the 10th-most congested city in the world in 2025, according to the Global Traffic Scorecard from INRIX, a transportation analytics firm. That's not exactly something to brag about, but L.A. was the eighth-most congested in 2024.

Compared with other major U.S. cities, L.A.'s con-

gestion ranked fourth, behind Chicago, New York City and Philadelphia, the scorecard found.

Throughout the mid-to-late 2010s, L.A. routinely ranked as having the worst traffic congestion anywhere in the world.

So what is going on? Experts cite several theories:

■ Reworked commuting habits spurred by the COVID pandemic.

■ The continued struggles of downtown Los Angeles, where office vacancies remain high.

■ L.A.'s already notorious congestion, which has long been so severe that it's easier for conditions to get slightly better than any worse.

That's not to say L.A. drivers had it easy, though. In 2025, the average Angeleno driver still spent 87

[See **Traffic**, A10]